

Galatians 3:6-14

Blessing or a Curse

Source: Dr. C. Norman Sellers, ThD · used by permission

Editor: _____

① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher / Leader prep	Group meeting
<i>Everyone</i>	<i>All group members</i>	<i>Teacher / Leader</i>	<i>Small group</i>

① BIBLICAL TEXT

Galatians 3:6-14 (NKJV)

6 *just as Abraham “believed God, and it was accounted to him for righteousness.”*

7 *Therefore know that only those who are of faith are sons of Abraham.*

8 *And the Scripture, foreseeing that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, preached the gospel to Abraham beforehand, saying, “In you all the nations shall be blessed.”*

9 *So then those who are of faith are blessed with believing Abraham.*

10 *For as many as are of the works of the law are under the curse; for it is written, “Cursed is everyone who does not continue in all things which are written in the book of the law, to do them.”*

11 *But that no one is justified by the law in the sight of God is evident, for “the just shall live by faith.”*

12 *Yet the law is not of faith, but “the man who does them shall live by them.”*

13 *Christ has redeemed us from the curse of the law, having become a curse for us (for it is written, “Cursed is everyone who hangs on a tree”),*

14 *that the blessing of Abraham might come upon the Gentiles in Christ Jesus, that we might receive the promise of the Spirit through faith.*

② DEVOTIONAL

***“Just as Abraham believed God, and it was accounted to him for righteousness.”
(Galatians 3:6)***

Abraham had nothing to offer God but an empty, sinful account — and yet God credited him with righteousness the moment he believed the impossible promise. That is the foundation of faith: not what we bring to God, but what God freely credits to those who simply believe Him.

Because of that same faith, we belong to a fellowship that spans every age — “sons of Abraham,” not by bloodline, but by believing. And the fruit of that faith is blessing: the good news that God justifies all who believe, Jew and Gentile alike, is meant to reach us today exactly as it reached Abraham then.

The law could only curse; it could never bless. So Christ became the curse in our place, hanging on the tree, so that Abraham's blessing — and the promised Spirit — could come to us through faith alone.

Reflect:

1. Where am I tempted to add "and..." to the gospel of grace — believing plus something else?
2. What would change this week if I lived like someone whose account is already credited with Christ's righteousness?
3. Who around me needs to hear that the "good news" really is good — with no bad news attached?

Lord, thank You that I am counted righteous not because of what I have done, but because I believed You.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

Proposition

Because the law can save no one — it can only curse those who fail to keep it perfectly — God has always justified sinners the same way He justified Abraham: by faith alone, apart from works. Christ became a curse in our place so that the blessing promised to Abraham might come to the nations, and so that all who believe might receive the promised Spirit through faith.

Introduction

There were many men in the Old Testament before Abraham who were men of faith. Abel — remember — offered a more excellent sacrifice than Cain, and God was pleased with his sacrifice (this is out of Hebrews chapter 11). Enoch pleased God and was raptured — which I'm going to be also; I'm going to hang on until the rapture! But he was raptured. The Lord just took him one day, took him up to heaven; he didn't die. And Noah — Noah prepared an ark. Remember that Noah was supposed to build an ark because there was going to be a flood. Well, what kind of a flood is that?

They were afraid there was going to be some flooding in New York City. And I couldn't help but think — this is an aside — couldn't help but think that they excluded God from their upcoming memorial at Ground Zero. No clergy. Not going to have any of that. God says, "Well, I think I'll send my messenger." There comes the hurricane. I can't believe there's not something to that.

In any case, Noah was supposed to build an ark. Flood. Rain's going to come. What? Rain? What's that? It took faith for a man to build an ark. That thing was big — you build that in your garage just in case, and everybody laughed. Noah, I think it was huge — it was as large as the USS Texas. My brother served on that in World War II. He was at Iwo Jima, helping Fred throw the bombs in there. That was a big ship, a battleship — and the ark was that large. And Noah showed his faith in doing exactly what God said.

But the word "faith" and the word "believe" do not occur in Scripture until Genesis 15:6 — applied to Abraham. God told Abraham that Eliezer would not be his heir, because it was true: Eliezer was born after God said, "I'm going to bless the whole world through you, and you're going to have an heir." And so Abraham said, well, how do I know that You're going to give me an heir? "The one who's born in my house is going to be my heir." That's the law. So God said, no — it's going to be from you. From your loins, from your body is going to come a child. And Abraham didn't understand until later on that it also included Sarah, because remember Hagar's situation and all that. So Abraham's seed was going to be large — many.

In fact, at the time when God promised him in Genesis 15:6, the Lord took him outside and said, "Look at the stars." Do you ever do that and think about Abraham? I do this — I was up in northern Florida, there are no streetlights, and way back in the boonies where Billy Tyson lives, Melanie and I walked out there and looked up. You can almost reach out and touch them. And a

huge number — count them! He said, "Count the stars, if you're able to." And I imagine Abraham started off, "No, can't do that. Can't do it." Well, that's the way your seed is going to be. What? I don't have one yet! It's like getting the olives out of the jar — you've got to get that one out first. And so He said, well, your seed are going to be like the stars of the heavens. Now, it doesn't mean that there will be just as many seed of Abraham as there are stars — He doesn't say that. They are innumerable, and your seed are going to be innumerable — that's what He's saying.

So both Abraham and Sarah were past childbearing. We look in the Old Testament and say, "Oh wow, look — Methuselah is 969 years, Adam 945," whatever it was, so they had children way past normal age. No, that's not it — because in Hebrews we're told that Sarah was past the age of bearing; it had ceased to be with her as with women. It wasn't merely that they were old — it was that this was, in itself, an unusual thing. In Genesis 17, before the child was born, Abraham was 99 and Sarah was 90, and that's when the child was born. But Abraham believed God — that's the key — he believed God, and God counted that faith for righteousness, as we'll see as we go along.

I. The Study of Faith — 3:6–9

A. The Foundation of Faith — 3:6

First of all, in verses 6 to 9, we have the study of faith. Faith's foundation is found in verse 6: "Just as Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him for righteousness." See, the Judaizers claimed to have the Old Testament on their side. They looked to Moses as their teacher — "Oh, Moses, he said this, this, this." And so we're on good ground when we say, keep the law. But then they also looked to Abraham. Remember what the Pharisees said to Jesus? "We have Abraham as our father." Well, okay, Paul said, let's go back to that then. So Paul backs them up to Abraham — almost 500 years before Moses, Abraham was saved by faith. He was justified.

Paul's favorite passage is Genesis 15:6. He quotes it again in Romans chapter 4, verses 3, 9, and 22 — so he loves that passage. You want to talk about salvation by grace through faith? Let me tell you about Abraham. Abraham believed God, and God counted that as righteousness.

So Abraham believed God, believed the impossible, and God counted that as righteousness. It's declared righteous — it's called imputation, theologically. Imputed something to him that he didn't have on his own, but because he believed God, then God said, okay, that's righteousness. It's a bookkeeping term — debits and credits. On his debit side he had nothing; in fact, all he had was sin. And on the credit side, he didn't have anything — he had sin and nothing. So God credited his faith. He believed God, and God credited his faith more than what he had over here. In fact, He wiped that out and gave him righteousness. You are righteous with God because you believed. Abraham believed God, and God put that on his credit account. He now has all kinds of credit.

So when the law came, the law did not change or nullify what God had promised to Abraham. He asked that question in verse 17 — did that change? Did the law change what Abraham

experienced, what God promised Abraham? No — and then he says, "Certainly not!" Mē genoito — Paul's favorite term when he says, absolutely not. So no, certainly not — it did not.

Then the law was brought in a long time after. We haven't talked much about dispensations — you understand what they are? There are seven dispensations in Scripture: starting over here with innocence, conscience, human government, the promise, law, the church, the millennium. Those are the dispensations where God gives a revelation to people about how they may serve Him — how to serve Him. But let me tell you something: in all of those dispensations, people are saved the same way. People are saved by grace through faith all the time. Those dispensations, including the law, are not telling people how to be saved — they're telling people how to live after they're saved. How do you please God? You please God by faith, by believing Him. That's what we're talking about.

So righteousness comes not by the law — it was brought in alongside because of the lack; the law God brought in to bring them unto Christ, and he's going to talk about that a little later, in chapter 4. So that's the foundation of faith — the foundation of faith is believing God and receiving righteousness.

B. The Fellowship of Faith — 3:7

And then there's the fellowship of faith, verse 7: "Therefore know that only those who are of faith are sons of Abraham." Boy, that's quite a statement. Only the ones who believe God are sons of Abraham. All you Jewish people, all you people who look back to Moses and then back to Abraham — Abraham is our father — if you're not of faith, you are not a son of Abraham. No matter what your family tree says, you're not a son of Abraham. That's what he's saying.

So then he says in this word — he says "know," "therefore know." Now the word "know," he's not saying, "Now you know." He's saying, I want you to know this — this is truth. The truth is that only those who are of faith are sons of Abraham. See, they claimed to be sons of Abraham, and Paul says, you have a choice: you can either be a son of Abraham and be of faith, or you can be of works and not be a son of Abraham. Which do you choose? You can't have it both ways. You are not a son of Abraham unless you are one of faith.

Now, down through the ages there have been those who believed and have been a part of the group called the sons of Abraham, and only those are included in it — all the way down from Abel on through the Bible, all the way through, and it will go on and on until, in the millennium — even in the millennium, same thing: you believe God, God declares it to you for righteousness. So all the way down, he says there have been those who are sons of Abraham — only those, only those who are sons of Abraham. So that's the fellowship of faith. We're fellowshiping in faith with all those from ages past, ages future, the now time — all sons of Abraham who are of faith. Now, that's the fellowship.

C. The Fruit of Faith — 3:8–9

Then the fruit of faith, verses 8 and 9 — what fruit does faith bring? Well, the Scripture says, this is verses 8 and 9: "The Scripture, foreseeing that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, preached the good news to Abraham beforehand, saying, 'In you all the nations of the earth shall be blessed.'" Well, where is that? Well, that's in Genesis chapter 12, verse 3. So then all

those who are of faith are blessed with faithful Abraham. Abraham believed God — if you're of faith, you'll be blessed with faithful Abraham too. Not just sons of Abraham, but blessed with faithful Abraham.

The news about God — that He would justify the Gentiles by faith — that's good news. Oh, wow! Not only the Jews, not only out of Abraham's loins, those physical Jews — not just those, but the whole world. Anyone who is of faith will be blessed with faithful Abraham. So, you see, salvation by works — that's bad news. If you say, "I have to work for my salvation," you'll never get salvation, because you'll never do enough work. On the other hand, salvation by faith is good news. That's the good news. That's the gospel.

Well, we start them on that — many churches, I think most churches, start people on that, and you hear them say — and they get a little garbled at times, but they'll stand up and say, "It's by grace through faith. You are saved by faith." And everybody's, "Oh yeah, yeah, saved by faith." And then we get them into the church, and we get them into — oh, well, but you've got to do this and this and this. If you don't do this, this, and this, then you are not a believer. Give them the good news, get them in, then you have to go over here and give them the bad news. That's what's happening all over the world, I think, today. That's contrary to the Bible. It won't work either — you get people all mixed up, trying to do this and trying to do that.

I heard one this morning, couldn't believe it. You've got a — tithe. Oh man, fine man — he has good intentions; I know him well, I did know him well 40, 50 years ago. But it's a shame that he now goes back in the Old Testament — Malachi 3:3 — "bring the old tithes to the storehouse." No, that's the law. You give as the Lord has prospered you; that's what we give, not bringing the law in. And he was giving them a whole dose of bad news this morning, all through the whole hour.

So, salvation is by grace. So today — even today — we're blessed with the blessings of Abraham by faith in Christ and His sacrifice on the cross. That's our legacy that comes to us from Abraham through the New Covenant, as we read just a minute ago in Hebrews chapter 8. So in the Millennial Kingdom — we're talking about way over here, starting by grace, Abel going on through; I believe that Adam and Eve were also believers — from there, all the way over, and we come clear to the millennium. In fact, the millennium will be the best picture of it, because in the Millennium, Christ will be reigning on the earth. Now, there will be some who won't believe, but for the most part there will be believers, and the whole world will be under the domination of Christ, under the obedience of all people who are there because of the salvation they have. But all of this, for the entire world, is through the Abrahamic Covenant and God's blessing to him. So that's the study of faith.

II. The Substitute for Faith — 3:10–12

But now the substitute for faith. And this is a little bit strange. In verses 10 through 12, we have some people saying that if you really kept the law, you would be saved — if you kept the law exactly, you would be saved. Now think about that; I'm not going to ask for many hands, but think about that. Does that sound right to you? Is that true — that if anybody kept the law, he would be saved? Strange. We'll see.

A. The Fabrication of Salvation by the Law — 3:10a

1. There is a curse connected to the Law.

So, labeled in verse 10a, the fabrication of salvation by the law. There is a curse connected to the law, and that curse was exacted when one does not keep the law. So you can't be saved by the law if you don't keep it. That's number one.

2. The curse is exacted when one does not keep the Law.

"For as many as are of the works of the law are under the curse; for it is written..." — the curse falls on the one who does not keep the law. So you can't be saved by the law if you don't keep it.

3. Suppose one does keep the Law?

But then, number two — suppose that someone did keep the law? If some person should say, "I'll keep the whole law, and I will be saved by that" — in verse 12, Paul is going to quote Leviticus 18:5. It says, "You shall keep My statutes and My judgments, which if a man does, he shall live by them: I am the LORD." So they say, see? "If a man keeps My commandments, he will live." But some say that means he'll have eternal life. But is that what it says? No. What it says is not eternal life, but if a man keeps the law, he's going to live a good life. Now, to the extent that he does, and in the areas he does, he will live a good life.

For instance, if a man kept the laws of marriage — what the law said about marriage — if he kept the laws of marriage, husband and wife together keeping what the law said about marriage, he would have a good life. If children obey their parents, it will be well with them, and you'll have a good and prosperous life in the land which the Lord God has given you — that's the first commandment with a promise, and the promise is: if you'll obey your parents, you will live a good and prosperous life in the land — Canaan, at that time — the land which God has given you.

What I'm saying to you is that there were promises — physical promises — for keeping the law, but it's not talking about eternal life; it's talking about physical life on the earth. So if you keep a good life, keep the law, you'll not be justified, and you'll not be saved by that.

Why am I saying that? You know, a lot of you are saying, wait a minute, what about original sin? How were you born? You were born a sinner. David says in Psalm 51, "I was shapen in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me." He was born a sinner. Look at that cute little kid, so wonderful, so sweet — and then he starts, something boiled up, and somebody did something in that life. You've got something in there. Every person is born in sin. And we sin because we are sinners — we don't become sinners because we sin.

So what I'm saying to you, then, is you can keep all you want — you can keep all the laws in the whole book — and you will not go to heaven, you will not receive justification, because nothing takes care of that original sin but the death of Christ on the cross.

4. The Law was weak.

And the law was weak. Paul says about the law, the law was weak. Look at it — Hebrews chapter 8, verses 7 and 8, says this: "For if that first covenant" — that is, the law — "had been faultless, no place would have been sought for a second." Why would you need another one if the first one was perfect? But — well, wait a minute — what was wrong with the law? Didn't God give the law? Wouldn't it be perfect if God gave it to them? Makes sense. But then he goes on to say, in verse 8, "Because finding fault with them, He said: 'Behold, the days are coming, says the Lord, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah.'" The old covenant didn't work. But then he says, "finding fault with them" — whose fault was it? The weakness of the law was the people over which the law was ruling. The weakness was them; they could not keep it. The enemy was them.

I remembered when I saw that — Commander Perry, Lake Erie, 1813, he sent a message concerning the battle with the British: "We have met the enemy, and they are ours." I heard about a little boy who was playing the commander in a play, and he got mixed up, and he says, "We've met the enemies, and he is us." Well, that's it — the enemy is us. "We've met the enemy, and the enemy is us" — finding fault with them. The enemy is us. We can't keep the law; we can't do it. So the weakness in the law with them was them. It's us. We can't do it.

Then even the breaking of one commandment makes the person guilty of the entire book. James 2:10 says, "For whoever shall keep the whole law, and yet stumble in one point, he is guilty of all." So what I'm telling you is the Bible does not teach that if anybody keeps the whole law, he will be justified. Not true. Salvation is by grace through faith, and that's throughout the entire Bible. So that's the fabrication of salvation by the law.

B. The Obstruction to Salvation by the Law — 3:11–12

Now the obstruction to salvation by the law — even the law says that a man must live by faith. Habakkuk 2:4 says, "Behold the proud" — referring to the Babylonians — "his soul is not upright in him, but the just shall live by faith." That's in the time of the law, Habakkuk, just before the Babylonian captivity.

Now, the verse from Habakkuk is quoted three times in the New Testament. Romans 1:17 tells who the just are. Galatians 3:11 tells how the just shall live. Hebrews 10:38 explains what "by faith" means, as it introduces the entire chapter 11, "by faith." So — the just, Romans; shall live, Galatians; by faith, Hebrews.

Now, that the law does not save should not surprise us. Salvation is by faith alone, and that's God's way of salvation in the entire history — the dispensations, in all the dispensations, all seven of them, salvation is always by grace through faith. They are not ways of salvation; they are ways of serving God after you are saved. So we have to live so that we may please God. We find that in the Scripture — how do we do that? Well, if we do that, we'll be rewarded by God here now, and then hereafter the reward will be there.

Hebrews 12:28 — you know, I have my own translation of that, and I believe it's right; talked to someone just yesterday, said, "Hey, that's a good translation" — that's right. Well, we'll see. Remember, the book of Hebrews is building and building and saying, you've walked by faith,

you've walked by faith, the law's done away, da-da-da-da. Hebrews 12:28, he says this: "Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom which cannot be shaken, let us hold fast to grace, that we may serve God acceptably with reverence and godly fear." Hold fast to grace — the only way we can serve God acceptably, the only way we can please God, is by holding fast to grace.

C. The Compensation of Salvation by the Law — 3:10b

So we have the fabrication of salvation, the obstruction of salvation, now the compensation of salvation by the law. He says, "Cursed is everyone who does not continue in all things which are written in the book of the law, to do them." Everyone who does not keep the law is cursed. And no one has kept the law — guess what? We are all under the curse. We're all cursed, all of us are cursed. So what can we do? What can be done, since we're all slaves of the law? Well, we'll see. The study of faith, the substitute for faith — now the solution of faith.

III. The Solution of Faith — 3:13–14 (Redemption by Christ)

A. Christ Became a Curse — 3:13

Verses 13 and 14, redemption by Christ — that's the solution. The law can't do it; Christ on the cross did do it. Christ became a curse, verse 13 says: "Christ has redeemed us from the curse of the law, having become a curse for us. As it is written, 'Cursed is everyone who hangs on a tree.'" Christ has redeemed us — that word "redeemed" there means to buy out of, to buy out of the slave market of sin, to take us out of there.

How did He do that? Well, He did it by becoming a curse for us. We're under the curse; He became the curse, and He did it for us. And that word "for us" can mean on behalf of us, but even other times it means in place of us. I believe that's what the meaning is here — He took the curse in our place. Now we don't have to bear the curse; the curse has already been borne. That shows that His death was a substitutionary death. He died for me. He died in my place. He died as me. So when Christ died, I died. I died.

And **Kennedy's question** — what will you answer if God says, "Why should I let you into My heaven?" The answer should be: I died. I died. My sins are paid for, because I died with Christ. When I believed, I became a part of those for whom He died. So the reason you should let me into Your heaven is because I am already dead. I'm dead to sin, and I have no sin against me. I am pure. I have the righteousness of Christ — 2 Corinthians 5:21. So, "I have been crucified with Christ."

And "Cursed is everyone who hangs on a tree," he says — that's a quote from Deuteronomy 21:23. This does not refer, in context, to the cross. You can't go back there and say, well, Deuteronomy is saying everyone who is crucified is a curse. That's not true, because the Jews did not crucify their people — they were usually stoned. But then they would hang them on a tree to shame them, so that they were cursed because of the crime that they did. But then he applies this now to Jesus hanging on the cross. In that act of Christ, the curse of the law was transferred from sinners to Him. The Lord took that curse that was on mankind and placed it on Christ. He bore that curse. We're no longer under the curse.

B. Christ Bestowed the Blessing — 3:14

So He became a curse — but He also bestowed a blessing. Verse 14 says, "For the blessing of Abraham might come upon the Gentiles in Christ Jesus, that we might receive the promise of the Spirit through faith." So the blessing comes in two parts, really.

The Gentiles received the blessing given to Abraham for all the nations of the earth: "And in you shall all the nations of the earth be blessed." And that blessing is justification by faith, apart from the works of the law — and that's available to all who believe.

Now, they received the blessings of salvation, but they also received the promise of the Spirit. The Holy Spirit is available to all who believe, when they believe. So again, Paul has emphasized that both salvation and sanctification are through faith, not by works. He has laid out where works are not involved — faith is involved.

We need people today — and all of us agree with this, I'm sure — people of faith, people who believe God: saved by faith, sanctified by faith, serving by faith. All other salvation, or sanctification, or serving are not pleasing to God. So without faith, it is impossible to please God. We have to have faith in every area to please God. Now — shall we please God, or shall we try to do it ourselves, and displease God?

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Grammar	Definition & Significance
v.6	πιστεύω (ἐπίστευσεν) <i>believed</i>	G4100 · episteusen · Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	STR: to have faith in, entrust. ATR: the aorist points to a definite, completed act of trust, not a process. Significance in context: Abraham's faith was a settled response to God's word, not an ongoing achievement he had to sustain.
v.6	λογίζομαι (ἐλογίσθη) <i>was accounted / imputed</i>	G3049 · elogisthē · Aor. Pass. Ind. 3rd Sg.	THAY: a bookkeeping term — to reckon to one's account. VINE: used of crediting something to a person that is not intrinsically his. Significance: righteousness was credited to Abraham's account by God; it was not something Abraham produced.
v.7	υἱός (υιοί) <i>sons</i>	G5207 · huiōi · Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: son; in Paul's usage, one who shares the father's defining character. Significance: sonship to Abraham is defined by faith, not physical descent.
v.8	προοράω (προϊδοῦσα) <i>foreseeing</i>	G4275 · proidousa · Aor. Act. Ptc. Nom. Fem. Sg.	ATR: Scripture is personified as foreseeing what God would do. Significance: the gospel to the Gentiles was anticipated within the Old Testament text itself, not a later addition to it.
v.8	προεευαγγελίζομαι (προεευαγγελίσατο) <i>preached the gospel beforehand</i>	G4283 · proeuēngelisato · Aor. Mid. Ind. 3rd Sg.	VINE: a compound occurring nowhere else in the NT, showing that good news was announced to Abraham in advance. Significance: the Genesis 12:3 promise was itself gospel — good news of justification by faith proclaimed before the cross.
v.8	ἐνευλογέω (ἐνευλογηθήσονται) <i>shall be blessed</i>	G1757 · eneulogēthēsontai · Fut. Pass. Ind. 3rd Pl.	Significance in context: the nations are the recipients, not the source, of this blessing — it comes to them 'in' Abraham's seed, by faith.
v.10	κατάρα (κατάραν) <i>curse</i>	G2671 · kataran · Acc. Sg. Fem.	MRV: contrasted throughout the LXX and NT with eulogia (blessing); a solemn pronouncement of judicial condemnation. Significance: the law's own verdict on lawbreakers is a curse, never a blessing.

v.10,13	ἐπικατάρατος (ἐπικατάρατος) <i>cursed</i>	G1944 · epikataratos · Nom. Sg. Masc. (adj.)	LXX: the term used repeatedly in the Deuteronomy 27 covenant curses. Significance: Paul ties the law's curse (Deut. 27:26) to Christ's curse (Deut. 21:23) with the same word, binding verses 10 and 13 together.
v.11	δίκαιος (δίκαιος) <i>just / righteous</i>	G1342 · dikaios · Nom. Sg. Masc.	STR: one who is in right standing. Significance: the 'righteous one' of Habakkuk 2:4 is defined by faith, not by law-keeping.
v.11	ζάω (ζήσεται) <i>shall live</i>	G2198 · zēsetai · Fut. Mid. Ind. 3rd Sg.	Significance in context: the life in view is the believer's ongoing life of faith — the same verse Paul cites here is quoted three times across Romans, Galatians, and Hebrews.
v.13	ἐξαγοράζω (ἐξηγόρασεν) <i>redeemed</i>	G1805 · exēgorasen · Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	THAY: to buy out of the marketplace, especially of purchasing a slave's freedom. ATR: a decisive, completed transaction. Significance: Christ's redemption is pictured as a slave-market purchase that permanently removes the believer from the curse.
v.13	γίνομαι (γενόμενος) <i>having become</i>	G1096 · genomenos · Aor. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	Significance in context: Christ did not merely bear a curse — He 'became' it, full identification with what sinners deserved under the law.
v.14	ἐπαγγελία (ἐπαγγελίαν) <i>promise</i>	G1860 · epangelian · Acc. Sg. Fem.	VINE: used throughout Galatians of God's unilateral pledge to Abraham, contrasted with the law. Significance: the Spirit is received the same way the original promise was received — by faith, not law-keeping.
v.14	πνεῦμα (πνεύματος) <i>Spirit</i>	G4151 · pneumatos · Gen. Sg. Neut.	Significance in context: the Spirit is the ongoing evidence of the Abrahamic blessing given to every believing Gentile, received by faith rather than earned by works.

Grammar key: Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
----------	--------

What is the “foundation of faith” in verse 6?	Abraham simply believed God, and God credited that faith to him as righteousness — not earned, but imputed.
Who are the true “sons of Abraham” (v.7)?	Only those who are of faith — not physical descendants, but everyone who believes as Abraham believed.
What is the “fruit of faith” described in verses 8–9?	The good news that God would justify the Gentiles by faith was preached to Abraham beforehand; all who believe are blessed together with him.
Why can no one be justified by keeping the law (vv.10–12)?	The law curses anyone who fails to keep all of it perfectly, and no one keeps it perfectly; the law's “weakness” was in the people under it, not in the law itself.
How did Christ solve the curse of the law (vv.13–14)?	He became a curse in our place, redeeming us from the law's curse so that the blessing of Abraham and the promised Spirit could come to us by faith.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Paul appeals to Abraham's example rather than starting with Moses and the law. Why would this argument have carried special weight with the Judaizers?

Leader Answer: The Judaizers claimed Abraham as their father and pointed to Moses as their authority. Paul shows that Abraham himself was justified by faith almost 500 years before the law existed — so law-keeping cannot be the basis of the relationship the Judaizers were claiming.

2. What does it mean that righteousness was “accounted” or “imputed” to Abraham (v.6)? How does this differ from righteousness being earned?

Leader Answer: Imputation is a credit to Abraham's account of something he did not produce himself — God declared him righteous on the basis of faith, not achievement. See the Greek Word Study on λογίζομαι.

3. Galatians 3:10–12 raises three problems with trying to be saved by keeping the law. What are they, and why does each one rule out law-keeping as a way of salvation?

Leader Answer: (1) The law curses anyone who breaks it. (2) Leviticus 18:5 promises only a good earthly life for law-keeping, not eternal life. (3) Even the law itself says the righteous live by faith (Hab. 2:4) — the law was never given as a path to salvation.

4. In what sense did Christ “become a curse” for us (v.13)? What does the word “redeemed” (ἐξαγοράζω) add to this picture?

Leader Answer: Christ took the very curse the law pronounced on lawbreakers, dying in the place

reserved for the cursed (Deut. 21:23). “Redeemed” pictures Him purchasing us out of slavery to that curse, as one buys a slave's freedom.

5. Verse 14 says the blessing of Abraham comes to the Gentiles “that we might receive the promise of the Spirit through faith.” How does this tie salvation and sanctification together?

Leader Answer: Both the initial blessing (justification) and the ongoing gift of the Spirit (for the Christian life) come the same way — by faith, not works. The Spirit is the continuing evidence that grace, not law, governs the believer's life.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key Truth
3:6–9	The Study of Faith	Abraham was justified by faith alone, and all who believe — Jew or Gentile — share his blessing as true sons of Abraham.
3:10–12	The Substitute for Faith	The law can only curse, never save; it demands perfect obedience no one can render, and even the law itself testifies that the righteous live by faith.
3:13–14	The Solution of Faith	Christ redeemed us by becoming a curse in our place, so that Abraham's blessing and the promised Spirit come to all who believe.

⑤ APPLICATION

Resting in an Imputed Righteousness

Galatians 3:6

Drawn from Commentary — The Foundation of Faith; FGR: Hodges, Absolutely Free; Ryrie, So Great Salvation.

Abraham brought nothing to the table but an empty account, and God credited him with righteousness the moment he believed. That is still how it works. Assurance was never meant to rest on how well we are keeping our own ledger — it rests on what God has already credited to those who believe. If Abraham's faith could be "accounted" as righteousness centuries before the law existed, our righteousness before God rests on the same kind of credit, not on our own performance.

Reflection: Am I resting in what has already been credited to me, or am I still quietly trying to build my own account?

Practical Step: This week, write down one place you are tempted to "earn" what God has already given freely, and replace the striving with a specific prayer of thanks.

Living as a True Son of Abraham

Galatians 3:7, 29

Drawn from Commentary — The Fellowship of Faith.

Sonship to Abraham was never a matter of family tree; it is a matter of faith, and it gathers believers from every age and every nation into one family. That fellowship is wider than our own church, denomination, or generation — it includes everyone, in every dispensation, who has simply believed God.

Reflection: Does my sense of belonging in this family depend on faith alone, or do I quietly add requirements before I welcome someone else into it?

Practical Step: Reach out to one believer outside your usual circle this week as a tangible sign of this shared family bond in Christ.

Refusing to Trade Good News for Bad News

Galatians 3:8–9

Drawn from Commentary — The Fruit of Faith; FGR: Hodges, The Gospel Under Siege; Wilkin, Confident in Christ.

The gospel preached to Abraham was pure good news — that God would justify the Gentiles by faith. It is easy, without meaning to, to start people on that good news and then quietly switch them to a bad-news gospel of required performance in order to "keep them in line." Scripture never does that, and neither should we.

Reflection: Where have I — in my own walk, or in how I disciple someone else — unintentionally turned good news into a conditional message?

Practical Step: This week, when you share your faith or disciple someone, consciously keep the gospel message free of add-on requirements.

Standing in the Freedom Christ Purchased

Galatians 3:13–14

Drawn from Commentary — Christ Became a Curse / Christ Bestowed the Blessing; FGR: Swindoll, The Grace Awakening.

Christ became a curse so that we would not have to bear one. Having been redeemed from the law's curse and given the promised Spirit by faith, there is no reason to return to law-keeping as the basis of our acceptance with God or as the engine of our obedience. Grace, not the law, is what we are called to hold fast to.

Reflection: What “law” am I quietly living under that Christ has already redeemed me from?

Practical Step: Identify one area of self-imposed, performance-based pressure, and replace it this week with a specific act of obedience motivated by gratitude rather than obligation.

End of Study · Galatians 3:6-14